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SANDY HUFFAKER For The Times

THE NORTE fire ignited Friday in south Orange County. Crews fight a house fire in San Juan Capistrano.

FIRES RAGE ON MULTIPLE FRONTS IN SOCAL

The Norte blaze in O.C. burns homes, leads to evacuations. Interstate 5 shuts down.

BY CLARA HARTER, RICHARD WINTON, RUBEN VIVES AND HANNAH FRY

Fierce Santa Ana winds caused a chaotic afternoon as a fast-moving fire burned through multiple hillside homes in south Orange County while a nearby blaze in San Onofre shut down Interstate 5 for hours.

The hot smoky conditions forced residents in San Clemente and San Juan Capistrano to flee and created traffic gridlock from Orange County to Oceanside as the key north-south highway was impacted by multiple fires just miles apart.

The Norte fire ignited in bushy foothills near San Juan Capistrano and San Clemente around noon and quickly grew to 465 acres, according to the Orange County Fire Authority. Six homes were damaged in a hillside enclave of multimillion-dollar properties near Via La Mirada, as officials urged residents to heed evacuation orders and head to local evacuation shelters.

Linda Verraster was on the deck behind her home in San Clemente, just south of the evacuation zone, on Friday afternoon, watching for signs it might be time to leave.

Temperatures in the area were in the mid-90s and winds howled with gusts up to 35 mph, a less-than-ideal situation for firefighters.

Verraster had already filled her cars with gas and began preparing what she

[See **Fires,** A9]

LAPD chief's tenure divides Bass, Raman

A clash over the handling of police, protesters

BY LIBOR JANY

In the race to become L.A.'s next mayor, the city's top cop — LAPD Chief Jim McDonnell — has become a lightning rod for debate.

The two candidates — incumbent Karen Bass and City Councilmember Nithya Raman — have staked out differing positions on how the Los Angeles Police Department has performed under McDonnell.

Raman has vowed to replace McDonnell, saying he has not "met the moment" given the department's response to federal immigration raids. Bass has publicly backed the chief she hired two years ago, saying the LAPD could be thrown into disarray if McDonnell is removed before the 2028 Olympic Games.

Raman's potential ouster of McDonnell and desire to push reforms on the LAPD has pitted her against the Los Angeles Police Protective League, the powerful union for rank-and-file officers that campaigned against Bass during her first election but is now backing her. The union has poured millions of dollars into attack ads against Raman, who has said she declined contributions from the organization in the past.

In an op-ed published in the Protective League's monthly magazine earlier this year, union president Richard Mendoza called the Democratic Socialists of America, which has endorsed Raman, an "imminent threat to our members."

Last week, Raman faced criticism for an Instagram video in which she appeared to slam McDonnell and the mayor, saying at one point, "only you can stop fascist liars." She later denied that she was referring to Bass or McDonnell, saying her remarks were improperly edited — and that she had the video pulled.

The Raman campaign did not respond to numerous requests for an interview about her vision for the LAPD.

Raman, a Harvard-educated urban planner, has sought to burnish her credentials as a political outsider by publicly calling for a

[See **Chief,** A7]

Israeli settlers attack West Bank villages

Violence against Palestinians has spiked in weeks ahead of election

BY SAM METZ AND LEO CORREA



LEO CORREA Associated Press

ISRAELI soldiers stand beside a wounded Palestinian man after they shot him in the leg on Friday.

Israeli settlers attacked Palestinian villages across the occupied West Bank on Friday, setting fire to cars and trees and beating residents and a foreign journalist, in the latest violence to disrupt the territory's annual olive harvest this month.

Local officials and the Palestine Red Crescent Society reported attacks in at least eight villages in the northern West Bank, where most of the olive groves are concentrated and tens of thousands of Palestinian families depend on them for income.

Settler violence against Palestinians has soared this year and spiked further in the weeks leading up to Israel's election on Oct. 27. The far-right government that has emboldened the settlers could soon be voted out of power — or win another term.

Israeli authorities have done little to stop the attacks, according to residents and rights groups, who say the military has aided, pro-

[See **West Bank,** A3]

Chaos engulfs Trump's team as vote nears

In the final stretch before midterms, the White House returns to a familiar disarray.

BY MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — President Trump bypassed his White House chief of staff last week in selecting Katie Zacharia as his press secretary and chief messenger, triggering days of scathing headlines about her credentials and abilities before her ignominious resignation on Friday.

Susie Wiles, that seniormost aide ostensibly in charge of the president's team, is facing his scrutiny over a different set of problems: widespread public anxiety over corruption in government under the Trump administration. The issue has surpassed the economy as the top concern of voters entering next month's election, according to a Fox News poll released this week.

Marco Rubio, the president's secretary of State and national security advisor, has been silent on Trump's decision to cut a deal with Moscow on diesel sales that could fuel Russia's war against Ukraine. The president's poll numbers have been below water across the board, but especially so on foreign policy, where over two-thirds of Americans disapprove of his job performance and support Kyiv's fight for freedom.

And on Thursday, the president was forced to reverse a course set out by Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth and the Pentagon to livestream the execution of a convicted mass shooter by firing squad.

In the final stretch of the 2026 midterms, nearly two weeks out from election day, a White House that has enjoyed relative stability over the last two years has returned to the state of disarray that characterized much of Trump's early political ca-

[See **Trump,** A7]

Press secretary already leaving

Katie Zacharia was scrutinized over her inaugural briefing and claim to be a lawyer. **NATION, A5**



DAMIAN DOVARGANES Associated Press

THE 2028 OLYMPICS' arts and culture program faces organizational and financial uncertainties.

LA28 questioned about its arts plan

At a state legislative hearing, critics express concerns about the Cultural Olympiad.

BY JANE HOROWITZ

With less than two years until the 2028 Olympic and Paralympic Games in Los Angeles, serious questions remain about funding and coordination for the Cultural Olympiad, the arts and culture program accompanying the Games.

The Cultural Olympiad is a measure of a host city's commitment to the creative arts and can have a lasting impact on a region's artistic legacy. The 2024 Olympics in Paris featured more than 2,500 projects over a period of three years. And while Los Angeles arts organizations and neighboring cities are already commissioning work and developing neighborhood celebrations, critics say a more formal and cohesive plan has failed to materialize.

At a legislative hearing Wednesday at the California Science Center, lawmakers pressed organizers for answers to a basic question: How much money will there be to support the Cultural Olympiad, and when will that money reach the artists and communities expected to bring it to life?

Former Los Angeles County Supervisor Zev Yaroslavsky, director of the Los Angeles Initiative at UCLA's Luskin School of Public Affairs, criticized the failure to mobilize cultural planning earlier. Los Angeles was awarded the Games in September 2017, giving it nearly 11 years to prepare.

"I'm not trying to point a finger here, but it just didn't happen," he said.

[See **LA28,** A14]

Voices **BILL PLASCHKE** COLUMNIST

Why Dodgers failed to three-peat

A stacked but ailing and aging roster came up short

The two World Series championship trophies royally entered Dodger Stadium in a blue convertible while being cradled by two October heroes.

The 2024 trophy was held by Freddie Freeman, whose grand slam toppled the New York Yankees.

The 2025 trophy was held by Miguel Rojas, whose home run stunned the Toronto Blue Jays.

On this bright afternoon late last March, the Dodgers' past shined and their future dazzled in a celebration that came with a promise.

It was elicited by an impromptu cheer by a pregame musician in a voice so loud, one could imagine it resonating until October.

"Three-peat!" shouted the man.

Yes, they were going for the three-peat, attempting to become the first team in National League history to win three consecutive championships.

And, yes, they had the stuff to do it, with a batting order led by the best player in baseball history and a pitching rotation led by a World Series MVP and the best reliever in baseball and the winningest manager in baseball and all the money and smarts in the world.

On opening day, as epitomized by Free-

[See **Plaschke,** A14]



MATHIEU LEWIS-ROLLAND Getty Images

A COMMUNITY GRIEVES

Mother says her son is the man who "heroically" stopped gunman in Thursday's attack at Silver Rail Elementary School, above, in Bend, Ore. **A6**

USC president faces hurdles

Beong-Soo Kim officially begins his tenure at a fraught time for the university. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

AI studios move into Culver City

Companies say they are drawn to the area by the legacy studios they hope their own work will rival. **BUSINESS, A10**

Weather

Heat; diminishing wind. L.A. Basin: 94/67. **B8**

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